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Enhancing Reading Proficiency Among Grade 2 Struggling Readers Through Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) in Albay Central School

INTRODUCTION

Reading is the most fundamental skill a child acquires in school. It is the gateway through which every other subject is learned and the means by which a child accesses knowledge, thinks critically, and participates fully in the life of the community. Recognizing this, the international community, through Sustainable Development Goal 4, has committed to ensuring that all children complete primary education with relevant and effective learning outcomes (United Nations, 2015), the most basic of which is the ability to read with understanding. The early grades of elementary school are where this commitment is either fulfilled or broken.

Reading does not develop naturally in the way spoken language does; it must be deliberately taught. In the primary grades, children are "learning to read" before they transition, at around Grade 4, to "reading to learn" (Chall, 1983). The Simple View of Reading (Gough & Tunmer, 1986) holds that reading comprehension is the product of decoding and language comprehension, so that a weakness in either one results in reading difficulty. Once word recognition becomes automatic, the reader's limited attention is freed for understanding meaning (LaBerge & Samuels, 1974). Grade 2 is therefore a decisive year: the foundations of word recognition must be secured if a child is to read for meaning in the grades that follow.

When these foundations are not secured, the consequences are serious and lasting. Juel (1988) found that a child who was a poor reader at the end of Grade 1 had an 88 percent probability of remaining a poor reader at the end of Grade 4. Stanovich (1986)

described this as the "Matthew effect" in reading: good readers read more and grow stronger, while poor readers read less and fall further behind. Torgesen (2004) thus called early reading failure a "devastating downward spiral" that is best prevented through early, intensive, and systematic intervention.

The Philippines faces this challenge on a massive scale. In the 2018 Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA), Filipino learners obtained a mean reading score of 340, the lowest among 79 participating countries and economies (OECD, 2019), and their score of 347 in PISA 2022 remained among the lowest of all participants (OECD, 2023). The problem begins early. The 2019 Southeast Asia Primary Learning Metrics (SEA-PLM) revealed that only 10 percent of Filipino Grade 5 learners reached the minimum reading proficiency expected at the end of primary school (UNICEF & SEAMEO, 2020), and the World Bank (2022) placed the country's learning poverty rate at about 91 percent, meaning that roughly nine in ten Filipino children at age 10 cannot read and understand a simple, age-appropriate text. To an elementary school teacher, these figures are not mere statistics; they describe the children who sit in our classrooms every day.

The government has responded through a series of laws and policies. Republic Act No. 10533, or the Enhanced Basic Education Act of 2013, mandates a learner-centered and contextualized curriculum that builds strong foundational skills. The Department of Education (DepEd) has implemented the Every Child a Reader Program (ECARP), revised the Philippine Informal Reading Inventory (DepEd Order No. 14, s. 2018), and launched the "Hamon: Bawat Bata Bumabasa" initiative (DepEd Memorandum No. 173, s. 2019). More recently, the National Learning Recovery Program (DepEd Order No. 13, s. 2023), Catch-Up Fridays (DepEd Memorandum No. 001, s. 2024), the MATATAG Curriculum (DepEd Order No. 10, s. 2024), and Republic Act No. 12028, or the Academic Recovery and Accessible Learning (ARAL) Program Act, have placed foundational literacy at the center of the national reform agenda.

Policies, however, succeed or fail in the classroom. The National Reading Panel (2000) found that phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension are best taught explicitly and systematically, and Wanzek and Vaughn (2007) reported that early interventions delivered in small groups yield meaningful gains for struggling readers. Central to such interventions are the materials teachers use. Vygotsky's (1978) Zone of Proximal Development suggests that learners progress best when given tasks slightly beyond their independent level, supported by appropriate scaffolding. Well-designed materials provide this scaffolding: decodable words let

children apply new letter-sound patterns with success, leveled passages build fluency and confidence, and guided questions model how good readers think about a text. Yet in many public schools, leveled and contextualized reading materials remain scarce, and commercially produced ones are often costly or distant from the learners' language and experiences, a concern made sharper in Albay, where most children speak Bikol at home.

At Albay Central School, these realities take on familiar faces. As an elementary school teacher, the researcher has witnessed Grade 2 learners who can recite the alphabet song but cannot tell the sound a letter makes, who confuse letters such as b and d, who read word by word and lose the meaning before reaching the end of a sentence, and who can sound out words yet cannot answer simple questions about what they have read. Just as telling are the behaviors that accompany these difficulties: avoiding reading aloud, looking away when called upon, and quietly waiting for a seatmate to answer. The beginning-of-the-year reading assessments administered in the school have likewise identified Grade 2 learners who are reading below the expected level for their grade. Without timely intervention, their reading gap will widen into a learning gap across all subjects.

In response, the researcher proposes the use of Reading Intervention Materials (RIM), a set of teacher-developed and contextualized materials designed for Grade 2 struggling readers. Anchored on the five components of reading, the RIM progresses systematically from letter-sound knowledge to word recognition, fluent reading of connected text, and comprehension. It includes letter-sound cards, decodable word lists, sight word cards, phrase and sentence strips, leveled passages and short stories drawn from familiar local settings, and guided comprehension activities, all delivered through small-group and one-on-one sessions. This study seeks to determine the extent to which the RIM enhances the reading proficiency of these learners. It is driven by a conviction every elementary school teacher holds: no child is too far behind to learn to read, and with the right support at the right time, every struggling reader can become a confident and independent reader.

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

This study aims to enhance the reading proficiency of Grade 2 struggling readers through the use of Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) at Albay Central School during the School Year 2026–2027.

Specifically, it aims to:

1. Determine the reading proficiency level of the Grade 2 struggling readers before the use of the RIM (pre-test) in terms of:
    a. letter-sound knowledge;
    b. word recognition;
    c. reading fluency; and
    d. reading comprehension.
2. Describe the Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) developed and utilized in the study in terms of their content, activities, and mode of delivery.
3. Determine the reading proficiency level of the Grade 2 struggling readers after the use of the RIM (post-test) in terms of:
    a. letter-sound knowledge;
    b. word recognition;
    c. reading fluency; and
    d. reading comprehension.
4. Ascertain whether there is a significant difference between the pre-test and post-test reading proficiency levels of the Grade 2 struggling readers.
5. Determine the level of acceptability of the RIM as evaluated by teachers and reading experts in terms of:
    a. content;
    b. format and design;
    c. language and readability; and
    d. usefulness.
6. Identify the challenges encountered by the teacher and the learners in the utilization of the RIM.
7. Propose a reading enhancement action plan based on the findings of the study.

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